



Amphitheater of El Jem

The largest amphitheater outside Italy and one of the best preserved Roman ruins in the world



The city of Thysdrus, present-day El Jem (or El Djem) in Tunisia, was one of the most important in Roman North Africa. The ruins of this once-great trading center—and most notably of its impressive amphitheater—have been preserved by burial under desert sands.

Projecting Rome's power

The building of the amphitheater is thought to have begun in 238 CE. Capable of holding up to 35,000 people, it was intended to provide a venue for spectacular events. However, construction did not go to plan due to political turmoil in the province—the year 238 saw six rulers vying for recognition as emperor. Some archaeological evidence suggests that building work was inadequately funded and possibly not even entirely finished.

Unlike others in Roman Africa, the amphitheater's structure is free-standing rather than cut into a hillside, adding to its grandeur. Its three levels of arched galleries are constructed of sandstone blocks built onto the bedrock of the plain with no foundations.

Thysdrus was occupied by Vandals in the 5th century, and then by Arabs in the 7th century, when it served as a fortress. The amphitheater remained almost intact until the 17th century, when some stones were removed for use as building materials.

► ARCHED GALLERIES

The surviving three tiers of arcades feature arches and columns in the Corinthian style, echoing those of Rome's Colosseum (see pp.102-103).

